

Astronauts Return to Earth After 237 Days and 100 Million Miles in Space

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Four astronauts are back on Earth after more than seven months living on the International Space Station. Their SpaceX capsule splashed down safely in the Pacific Ocean near Los Angeles on Thursday morning.

The Crew-12 team included NASA astronauts Jessica Meir and Jack Hathaway, European Space Agency astronaut Sophie Adenot and Russian **cosmonaut** Andrey Fedyaev. They launched on Feb. 13 and spent 237 days in **orbit**. During that time, they circled Earth more than 3,792 times and traveled over 100 million miles.

Recovery teams on special ships quickly reached the capsule and brought the crew aboard. After routine medical checks, the astronauts were set to travel to NASA's Johnson Space Center in Houston.

For Meir and Fedyaev, this was their second trip to space. For Hathaway and Adenot, it was their first.

The crew spent hundreds of hours on science experiments. One project explored ways to make **stem cells** in space, which could someday be used in medical treatments. Another tested a machine that makes **IV fluids**, the liquids doctors give patients through a tube, whenever they are needed. That could be very useful on long trips far from Earth. Other studies looked at nutrition in space and how blood flows in the body without **gravity**.

NASA says this research will help keep people healthy on future missions to the Moon and Mars.

Meir also made four **spacewalks** during the mission, bringing her career total to seven. That places her third among NASA women for the most **spacewalks**.

NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman thanked the crew and said building the ability to do missions like this again and again will help humans go farther.

Word Treasure

orbit -- The curved path an object takes as it travels around a planet or star.

cosmonaut -- A Russian astronaut.

stem cells -- Special cells that can grow into many different kinds of cells in the body.

IV fluids -- Liquids given to patients through a thin tube directly into a vein.

spacewalks -- Times when astronauts leave their spacecraft in space suits to work outside.

gravity -- The force that pulls objects toward each other, like what keeps us on the ground.

Background you need

The International Space Station is a large laboratory that circles Earth, where astronauts from several countries live and work for months at a time.

Crews travel to and from the station in capsules, and SpaceX capsules return by splashing down in the ocean, where recovery ships pick them up.

Living without gravity changes the human body, so scientists study astronauts to learn how to keep people healthy on long trips.

NASA hopes to send people back to the Moon and later to Mars, which will require much longer missions than a stay on the station.

Break it down

LEAD: Crew-12 returns safely after 237 days on the International Space Station

KEY EVENT: Splashdown in the Pacific Ocean near Los Angeles

+ - WHO: Jessica Meir, Jack Hathaway, Sophie Adenot and Andrey Fedyaev

+ - WHEN: Thursday; launched Feb. 13

+ - NUMBERS: More than 3,792 orbits and over 100 million miles

SCIENCE: Stem cells, IV fluid machine, nutrition and blood flow studies

MILESTONE: Meir's four spacewalks bring her total to seven

WHY: Research supports future Moon and Mars missions

Why it matters

Learning how to keep astronauts healthy for months is a key step before people can safely travel to the Moon and Mars, and some of the research could also help medicine on Earth.

Test what you remember

1. How many days did the Crew-12 astronauts spend in orbit?
 - (A) 100
 - (B) 3,792
 - (C) 237
 - (D) 365
2. Where did the capsule splash down?
 - (A) In the Gulf of Mexico
 - (B) In the Atlantic Ocean near Florida
 - (C) In the Pacific Ocean near Los Angeles
 - (D) In a lake in Texas
3. Which astronaut is from the European Space Agency?
 - (A) Sophie Adenot
 - (B) Andrey Fedyaev
 - (C) Jack Hathaway
 - (D) Jessica Meir
4. What could the IV fluid machine be useful for?
 - (A) Taking photos
 - (B) Cleaning the space station
 - (C) Long trips far from Earth
 - (D) Growing plants
5. How many spacewalks has Jessica Meir done in her career?
 - (A) Five
 - (B) Seven
 - (C) Four
 - (D) Ten
6. About how far did the crew travel?
 - (A) 1 billion miles
 - (B) 1 million miles
 - (C) Over 100 million miles
 - (D) 10 million miles

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: A 4: C 5: B 6: C

1. NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman: Says building the ability to do missions like this again and again will help humans go farther.